

Internet Explorer, till now a separate feature of Windows, was now integrated into the Windows user interface—one of the more notable examples being the ‘Active Desktop’, which let you turn your desktop into a Web page.

Coming together—Windows 2000

In the beginning of 2000, Microsoft gave us Windows 2000, which blurred the line between Windows 98 and Windows NT. Initially called Windows NT 5.0, it was based on the rock-solid NT kernel, but promised to be as user-friendly as Windows 98. However,



Windows 2000 was still not targeted towards the home user—Microsoft had other plans for them.

Earlier versions of Windows NT had come with support for platforms other than Intel’s x86 platform—like IBM’s PowerPC—but didn’t enjoy so much popularity on these platforms. With Windows 2000, Microsoft ditched support for these platforms, making Windows 2000 a purely x86 compatible OS. It supported the FAT32 filesystem along with the NTFS, making it easier for users to upgrade from Windows 98.

All said and done, the ‘hybrid kernel’ (see Chapter 1) architecture of Windows 2000 was quite robust, and it was undoubtedly the most stable version of Windows yet.

That’s it, I’m done—Windows Me

Later in 2000, Windows Millennium Edition was released for the home user. This was the last version of Windows to be based on Windows 95. One of the most notable things was that it didn’t support DOS in the same way—DOS programs could no longer access hardware directly.